



What the Waiting Did

Student copy (project or hand out)

1 Waiting used to be the ordinary weather of a life. You wrote a letter and waited weeks for the reply. You wanted a song and waited for the radio to play it. You missed a fact and waited, sometimes for years, to learn it. None of this was a virtue. It was the plain cost of being alive, back before that cost was quietly abolished.

2 The abolition is a gift, and it would be foolish to pretend otherwise. A parent now reaches a child in a held breath. A test result arrives before the dread has time to settle. The busy signal, the layaway counter, the long line at the bank: speed has retired a hundred small daily humiliations, and almost nobody who lived through them misses the waiting itself. We bought back the time we used to lose, and we were right to want it.

3 And yet something went out of the world along with the waiting, something we were never given a price for. The wait had never been only an absence; it was a room. Inside that room the mind did its slow and unsupervised work, rehearsing and dreading and hoping and changing its own position before anyone else could watch. The letter you waited three weeks for was answered, in part, by the three weeks. Boredom, the most maligned of states, was often just thinking with the lights off.

4 We did not only lose the wait; we lost what the wait used to make in us. Patience, yes, but also the second thought, the cooled temper, the letter never sent. Speed keeps its promises. It is the promises of slowness that go unrecorded, because a thing that never happens leaves behind no receipt.

5 So the real question is not whether to go back. Nobody is going back, and the radio is not returning to make us wait for the song. We are very good now at not waiting. The question is smaller, and harder. It is whether a life that need never pause has quietly stopped doing the work that only the pause once did. And whether we would even notice the loss now, with nothing left in the day to make us wait for it.

AP-style multiple choice:

1. The phrase “And yet” that opens the third paragraph chiefly serves to
 - A) concede that speed has brought no real benefits
 - B) mark the turn from granting speed’s value to questioning its cost
 - C) introduce a personal anecdote from the writer’s own life
 - D) restate the essay’s conclusion before the evidence
2. The brief sentence “Speed keeps its promises.” set against the longer sentence after it primarily works to
 - A) supply a statistic that proves speed is efficient
 - B) let the plain, clipped line throw emphasis onto the ‘promises of slowness that go unrecorded’
 - C) make an emotional plea to give up modern technology
 - D) express the writer’s uncertainty about the argument

Discussion questions:

1. The writer spends a whole paragraph agreeing that almost no one misses waiting before arguing that we lost something real. How does conceding the other side first change the way the later claim lands?
2. The essay reframes waiting as “a room” where the mind works. Find one other place where the writer turns an abstract idea into something concrete, and explain what that lets the reader see or feel.

Writing prompt (homework or extended in-class, Q3 argument):

The writer suggests that a life that “need never pause” may have “quietly stopped doing the work that only the pause once did.” Defend, challenge, or qualify the claim that something valuable is lost when waiting disappears from everyday life. Use your own knowledge, observation, or reading.